Indeed, populists frequently criticize the international elites that dominate bodies like the WTO, refusing to cooperate with such institutions and prioritizing their own countries' needs (Copelovitch and Pevehouse 2019). They express concern about relative rather than absolute gains, wishing to increase their share of the pie rather than to expand the size of the pie as a whole; such a preference undercuts international collaboration (Mearsheimer 2001). Campaign statements, including "America First";[2] "We are for local, against global";[3] and "Brazil Above Everything,"[4] make clear that populists decry international cooperative efforts and prefer to turn inward.

Populists portray the global elite as corrupt and out-of-touch and IOs as infringing on their national sovereignty. For example, US president Donald Trump, in his first term, asserted that one of his political opponents was "the candidate of … globalists … ripping off the United States with bad trade deals and open borders."[5] Similarly, former British prime minister Boris Johnson felt "very, very frustrated by people being told what to do by nanny in Brussels" and wanted to "take back control … of our money, our borders, and our laws" from the EU.[6]

Given populists' repeated calls to tear down the global architecture, it is no wonder that the rise of populism has spread fears of international calamity among nonpopulists. At stake are no less than the unprecedented levels of peace and global economic prosperity that have been driven, in part, by globalization and international cooperation (Russett and Oneal 2001; Gartzke 2007; Ikenberry 2011a). Critics worry that if populists upend the trade regime, for example, the global policies and processes that practitioners have refined over decades to guide global commerce will fall apart, with enormous economic and political consequences. If populists undercut global development institutions or organizations tasked with maintaining peace between rivals, they could thrust many individuals into poverty, forced migration, or conflict. Should populists block cooperation on environmental degradation and climate change, the planet may become engulfed in irreversible heat and biological devastation (Barnett and Adger 2007; Colgan, Green, and Hale 2021).

Yet others argue that populists offer a necessary corrective for an international order that has expanded too fast and intruded too far into issues that should be under countries' purviews (Rodrik 2017). Critics point to IOs' sprawling bureaucracies and large budgets and argue that their waste and